entire world is focused on Cuba. The missiles played their positive role." Khrushchev apparently wanted to soften the blow to Castro by saying that the withdrawal of the missiles might be temporary. Gromyko, along with two party officials, was entrusted with the task of putting those thoughts on paper.[18]

But even before getting into negotiations with Kennedy or informing Castro about the withdrawal of the missiles, the worried Khrushchev decided to start the de-escalation process right away. What only yesterday had been welcomed with great relief—the delivery of nuclear warheads for the R-14 intermediate-range missiles to Cuba on the cargo ship *Aleksandrovsk*—was now perceived as a potential problem to deal with. On Khrushchev's orders, Defense Minister Rodion Malinovsky cabled General Issa Pliev, the commander of the Soviet forces in Cuba, to ship the warheads back. "In connection with the fact that US Navy is blockading approaches to Cuba, we made a decision not to send 665 and 668 RP [missile regiments] to you. You should not unload warheads for R-14 from transport ship *Aleksandrovsk*," read the cable. "If they are already unloaded, organize secret loading back onto *Aleksandrovsk*," continued Malinovsky. "Transport ship *Aleksandrovsk* with the warheads for R-14 should be prepared for transportation back to the Soviet Union." In case of emergency, the captain was to sink the ship with the nuclear warheads.[19]

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ON OCTOBER 25, THE DAY KHRUSHCHEV DECIDED TO REMOVE his ballistic missiles from Cuba in exchange for Kennedy's promise not to invade the island, the Soviets suffered a major public relations defeat at a meeting of the UN Security Council, where they tried to deny the existence of such missiles in Cuba.

The key figures in the televised drama were the American representative to the UN, Adlai Stevenson, and his Soviet counterpart, Valerian Zorin. The Soviet representative left himself open to an attack by Stevenson when he claimed that the Americans had nothing but "false evidence" to prove the presence of Soviet missiles in Cuba. Why, he asked,